

Citizens, Politicians and the Media: Evaluating Democratic Processes

SF2222; Spring 2025; 15 högskolepoäng/15 Higher education credits
University of Gothenburg

Ann-Kristin Kölln, Department of Political Science
ann-kristin.kolln@gu.se (course coordinator)

Wilma Holmestrand, Department of Political Science
wilma.holmestrand@gu.se (course administrator)

Table of contents

1.	General information	3
1.1.	Content of the course	3
1.2.	Logic of the course	3
1.3.	Academic integrity and use of artificial intelligence	4
1.4.	Literature	5
2.	The input-heavy side: Lectures	5
2.1.	Lecture 1. Introduction and welcome.....	6
2.2.	Lecture 2. Political systems and media systems.....	6
2.3.	Lecture 3. Democratic theory and empirical research	6
2.4.	Lecture 4. The quality of public opinion.....	7
2.5.	Lecture 5. Political participation.....	7
2.6.	Lecture 6. Models of voting behaviour.....	8
2.7.	Lecture 7. Political representation I: What is representation and who is represented?	8
2.8.	Lecture 8. Political representation II: Ideological and policy (in)congruency	9
2.9.	Lecture 9: The Swedish national election studies: over 60 years of electoral research....	9
2.10.	Lecture 10. Election campaigns: professionalized, marketized; individualized?	10
2.11.	Lecture 11. Election campaigns: negative campaigning	10
2.12.	Lecture 12. Media effect theories	11
2.13.	Lecture 13. Changing media environments: Threat to democracy?	11
2.14.	Lecture 14. Mediatization – the impact of media on politics.....	12
2.15.	Written exam	12
3.	The output-heavy side: Research review	13
3.1.	Purpose and organization.....	13

3.2.	The process of writing the review	14
3.3.	The final seminar	15
4.	Course requirements and grading.....	15
5.	Compensatory tasks.....	16
5.1.	Compensatory tasks for missed supervision or workshop	16
5.2.	Compensatory tasks for missed final seminar (presentation and discussant)	17
6.	About equal treatment.....	17

1. General information

The schedule and all other information are available from the course web site (CANVAS SF2222). Any changes, additions, or other messages will be posted there. Please check your GU student email address and the Canvas web site regularly during the course.

1.1. Content of the course

A major goal of democracy is to realize “the will of the people.” But how should this be achieved? How is it achieved in reality? To find out, this course focuses on three groups of actors: citizens, politicians, and the media. We consider research on voting behaviour, political psychology, political participation, and political representation. Moreover, we examine theories and empirical research on political communication, journalism and media. What does this research tell us about these actors and how they interact under different circumstances? How do these actors, and the relations between them, fulfill requirements imposed by different models of democracy? What does research reveal about how various democratic values can be realized?

Specifically, the course has three aims:

1. To develop your knowledge of, and ability to critically evaluate theories and empirical research on voting behaviour, public opinion, political psychology, political participation, political representation, political communication, journalism and media.
2. To develop your ability to analyze democratic issues in light of empirical research. To what extent do *current* democratic processes live up to the ideals and assumptions of normative models of democracy? Which democratic reforms seem promising given that we want to realize certain democratic models and values?
3. To develop the participants’ academic writing and oral presentation skills.

1.2. Logic of the course

The theoretical and empirical content of the course is described in detail below where the lectures are outlined. The pedagogical idea of the course can be summarized as structured into an “input-heavy” part and an “output-heavy” part.

Input-heavy part – *learning how others think*

The introduction is followed by a series of lectures describing theories and results generated by a number of related research fields. This part is divided into overarching themes:

- a. Introduction to democracy theory and systemic level analyses (lectures 2-3),
- b. Citizens (lectures 4-6),
- c. From citizens to Politicians (lectures 7-11),
- d. Media (lectures 12-14)

The aim of this part of the course is to provide a good overview of what research has shown so far. This knowledge is tested in a written exam about halfway through the course. The exam is based on the lectures and literature covered to this point.

When studying, students are encouraged to systematically create their own summaries of each lecture and of the corresponding literature. Such summaries are sometimes called portfolios and become a concrete result of the course for the students to bring with them. They will also help students in the second part of the course as they provide a basis for the research review. Students are also encouraged to study together, discussing interpretations of the literature.

Output-heavy part – *writing and presenting yourself*

After the exam, students start working on a research review aiming at deepening your understanding of a specific area. The topic of the research review is chosen based on the lectures from the first part of the course. Each lecture has a specific theme that will inspire the students to further analyses. Students are encouraged to raise questions in class and during lectures connected to areas of their specific interest. The task of the students is to write a research review by 1) formulating a broad research problem; 2) developing more specific research questions following from the general research problem, as well as 3) answering these research questions analytically based on existing research.

1.3. Academic integrity and use of artificial intelligence

We take academic integrity very seriously. To fulfill the course requirements, you therefore have to conduct a self-teaching module on Canvas called Introduction to Academic Honesty on academic integrity. It takes ca 20 minutes and you can try as many times as you like. But you have to pass it to fulfill the course requirements.

In this course, the use of generative AI to create content for examination items is completely prohibited. However, it is allowed to use AI tools to improve the language, e.g., in the research review. Students who do not follow this rule will be reported to the Disciplinary Board for using “unauthorized aids” (see GU's rules for disciplinary matters). Add a note in your research review that clarifies how and for what purposes you have used AI tools.

To further help you avoid any suspicions of plagiarism, we list below some of the basic—and hugely important—principles for independent academic writing. Any attempt of fraudulent behavior will be documented.

- Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the origin of the information and knowledge conveyed by the text.
- Academic texts are characterized by independent and self-designed writing.
- In combination, the above principles mean that in academic writing we use the ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, conclusions of others, but we make clear the origin of these by quoting and referring. We communicate with, build on, and credit previous research, authors, sources, **but** we do not copy them! Copying is plagiarism, which is the same as cheating.
- Some examples of plagiarism: 1) Copying an existing text; 2) moving and deleting a few words from an existing text; 3) translating an existing text from another language; 4) copying from a previous assignment you wrote (self-plagiarism). Please note that none of these examples qualify as legitimate academic writing regardless of whether a reference is present or if the text is presented as one's own description and / or analysis.
- There should be no doubt whatsoever in the text about which ideas, thoughts, arguments,

opinions and conclusions are yours (absent a reference) and which arguments you obtained from other texts (reference to the author included). There are different reference styles (see more about this at <http://www.ub.gu.se/skriva/referensstilar/>) but a good rule of thumb, for maximum transparency, is to include the reference in the text, like this: (author surname, year, page), i.e. (Sikkink, 2000, 13).

- When an author you read uses particular wording to describe something, and you wish to use this exact wording in your text, **this wording should be marked as a quote**, with a reference that includes a page reference, such as (author surname, year: page). As stated, always including page numbers in the references in the text – whether cited or not – is a good rule of thumb!

- To put it simply, you avoid plagiarism 1) by always writing independently (never ‘copy and paste’), 2) by quoting, and 3) by the careful and frequent use of references.

- The Department of Political Science uses the Urkund control system against plagiarism. Our teachers are also very good at detecting texts that are not self-authored through our own critical reading experience. We are obliged to report suspicion of cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or even a suspension from education.

- If you use any artificial intelligence for writing your text, you have to add at the end of your review a declaration explaining exactly how you used it.

Additional information and knowledge on ‘Searching and citing,’ ‘Plagiarism,’ ‘Language support’ and the webcourse on ‘Academic Honesty’ is available at UoG:s Student Portal (student environment & rules > disciplinary matters).

1.4. Literature

We do not have a textbook for this course. All of the required literature comes in form of individual research articles and chapters, listed below for each lecture. These form the basis for the exam. But in order to do well on the course, it is advisable to read more broadly. We suggest two books for that.

- Dalton, Russell J. 2020, seventh edition. *Citizen Politics. Public Opinion and Political Parties in Advanced Industrial Democracies*. Washington DC: CQ Press.
- Iyengar, Shanto. 2018, fourth edition. *Media Politics. A Citizen's Guide*. New York: WW Norton & Co. (The third edition is also ok).

2. The input-heavy side: Lectures

Below you find outlines of the lectures of the course, including an abstract of the topics covered and the relevant course literature. It is advisable, but not necessary, that you read the texts before the lectures. Please that some readings are marked as “optional”; they are relevant for the topic but are not included in the texts for the examinations.

2.1. Lecture 1. Introduction and welcome

Ann-Kristin Kölln

Abstract: This first meeting includes important practical information and serves as a more formal introduction of the course. We also aim to get to know each other a bit more. Furthermore, specific study techniques will be suggested.

2.2. Lecture 2. Political systems and media systems

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: The conditions for public opinion and democratic debate undoubtedly vary across nations. In recent years, many studies have focused on how political systems as well as media systems influence how citizens, political elites and media interact to shape opinions and form a basis for political knowledge. This lecture provides an overview of systemic level factors that are important to the understanding of the actors and relationships between actors that we talk about in this course. We discuss election systems, party systems and media systems and how these relate to each other.

- Hallin, Daniel & Mancini, Paolo (2004): *Comparing Media Systems: Three Models of Media and Politics*. Cambridge: Cambridge U P (chapters 1-4; 8-9). (Found as e-book via the library of the University of Gothenburg)
- Dalton *Citizen Politics*, Chapter 7 (optional)
- Iyengar *Media Politics*. Chapter 2 (optional)

2.3. Lecture 3. Democratic theory and empirical research

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: All empirical research on democracy and political behavior rests on some normative assumptions of what a good democracy ought to be. Usually these are tacit assumptions, clearly guiding research questions and coloring conclusions, but seldom are they made explicit or discussed critically. This introductory lecture puts different normative ideals at the forefront. By presenting and discussing alternative *Models of Democracy*, this lecture highlights the sometimes conflicting normative values that underpin different approaches to the study of citizen behavior, public opinion formation, political representation and media coverage. The purpose of the lecture is to present a broad introduction to the fundamental normative ideas that the concept of democracy highlights – as well as to provide analytic tools for making normative assessments of the state of democratic performance in contemporary societies.

- Althaus, Scott. (2012). "What's Good and Bad in Political Communication Research? Normative Standards for Evaluating Media and Citizen Performance". In Holli Semetko & Margaret Scammell (Eds.) *The SAGE Handbook of Political Communication*. London: Sage Publications Ltd.
- Berelson, Bernard (1952). "Democratic Theory and Public Opinion." *Public Opinion Quarterly* 16:313-330.

- Strömbäck, Jesper. (2005) “In Search of a Standard: four models of democracy and their normative implications for journalism”. *Journalism Studies, Volume 6, Number 3, 2005, pp. 331-345*
- Zaller, John (2003) “A new standard of news quality: Burglar alarms for the monitorial citizen”. *Political Communication 20:2 109-130*
 - Iyengar. *Media Politics*. Chapter 1 (optional)
 - Dalton *Citizen Politics*, Chapter 1 (optional)

2.4. Lecture 4. The quality of public opinion

Ann-Kristin Kölln

Abstract: This lecture is about the often-debated issue of the (lack of) quality of public opinion. We start by discussing what public opinion is and how we can measure it. The lecture then moves on to investigate the role of information in public opinion before introducing the concepts of “shortcuts” and “frames” in this context. Shortcuts sometimes help (uninformed) citizens to make informed choices; frames refer to ways in which an issue or event is presented. Finally, we also discuss the role of the media in affecting political knowledge. Overall, the point of this lecture is to argue that opinions are individually flawed but that this has little consequences for the quality of democracy.

- Chong, Dennis, & Druckman, James N. (2007). Framing Theory. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 10(1), 103-126.
- Jerit, Jennifer, Barabas, Jason, & Bolsen, Toby (2006). Citizens, knowledge, and the information environment. *American Journal of Political Science*, 50(2), 266-282.
- Lau, Richard R., & Redlawsk, David P. (2001). Advantages and disadvantages of cognitive heuristics in political decision making. *American Journal of Political Science*, 45(4), 951-971.

2.5. Lecture 5. Political participation

Ann-Kristin Kölln

Abstract: This lecture takes a closer look at the causes and motivations underlying different types of political participation. This includes large-scale collective activities such as electoral participation, party activities, as well as more individual modes of exercising influence. The key question is why some people participate in political processes whereas others don't and how this might differ across different forms of political participation. The key message of this lecture is that citizens in Western democracies are today politically active but in different ways and for different reasons, which sometimes attenuates political inequalities and sometimes not.

- Schlozmann, Kay L., & Brady, Henry E. (2022). Political Science and Political Participation, In Marco Giugni & Maria Grasso (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Political Participation* (pp. 25-44). Oxford, Oxford University Press. (e-book)
- Theocharis, Yannis & van Deth, Jan W. (2018). The continuous expansion of citizen participation: a new taxonomy. *European Political Science Review*, 10(1), 139-163.

- Willeck, Claire & Mendelberg, Tali (2022). Education and Political Participation. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 25, 89-110. [only pages 89-94]

2.6. Lecture 6. Models of voting behaviour

Ann-Kristin Kölln

Abstract: This lecture provides a bird's eye view of the historically dominant explanations of voting behavior. It introduces the broad assumptions and thinking behind three important models: the sociological, the socio-psychological and rational choice models. It then evaluates the models and identifies the main weaknesses of each. Do any of these models accurately summarize current electoral behavior? How do they fare individually as well as jointly? Overall, this lecture argues that citizens' voting decisions are one of the most researched phenomena in political science but still highly difficult to predict because of their complexities and contingencies.

- Anderson, Christopher J. (2007) The end of economic voting? Contingency dilemmas and the limits of democratic accountability. *Annual Review of Political Science*, pp. 271-296,
- Bartels, Larry M. (2010). The Study of Electoral Behavior. In Leighley, Jan E., (Ed.). *The Oxford Handbook of American Elections and Political Behavior*. Oxford, Oxford University Press. (e-book)
- Evans, Geoffrey (2000). The continued significance of class voting. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 3(1), 401-417.

2.7. Lecture 7. Political representation I: What is representation and who is represented?

Jacob Gunderson

Abstract: In this lecture, we discuss political representation and the political inclusion of historically underrepresented groups. Over time, many older democracies have gotten more inclusive as previously marginalized groups have gained visibility, political clout and representation. Some of the central questions of the lecture are the following: What does representation mean? Where are we today? What are the underlying causes behind variation in representation? In other words, the lecture discusses definitions, provides descriptive information, and engages with issues of cause and effect.

- Carnes, Nicholas and Noam Lupu. (2023). "The Economic Backgrounds of Politicians". *Annual Review of Political Science* 26: 253-270.
- Dancygier, Rafaela, Lindgren, Karl-Oskar, Nyman, Pär and Vernby, Kåre (2021), Candidate Supply Is Not a Barrier to Immigrant Representation: A Case-Control Study. *American Journal of Political Science*, 65: 683-698. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12553>
- Reynolds, Andrew. (2013). "Representation and Rights: The Impact of LGBT Legislators in Comparative Perspective." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 259-74. doi: 10.1017/S0003055413000051.
- Urbinati, Nadia and Mark E. Warren. (2008). "The Concept of Representation in Contemporary Democratic Theory". *Annual Review of Political Science* 11: 387-412.

- Wängnerud, Lena (2009) Women in Parliaments: Descriptive and Substantive Representation. *Annual Review of Political Science* 12:51-59.

2.8. Lecture 8. Political representation II: Ideological and policy (in)congruency

Jacob Gunderson

Abstract: This lecture aims to provide a broad overview of the concepts of responsiveness and congruence, i.e., the extent to which public opinion matches the preferences of their representatives in office and the extent to which public opinion affects public policy. In doing so, the lecture focuses both ideological and policy congruency with an eye towards which groups in society are better represented. In terms of policy, we focus on lobbying and income as two manifestations of the role of money as a determinant of representation. We also focus on parties and politicians—as the bearers of representation—in asking who parties prioritize and the extent to which elites have accurate mental models of what the represented want.

- Burstein, Paul. (2003). "The Impact of Public Opinion on Public Policy: A Review and an Agenda." *Political Research Quarterly* 56 29-40.
- Ezrow, Lawrence, Catherine De Vries, Marco Steenbergen, and Erica Edwards. 2010. "Mean voter representation and partisan constituency representation: Do parties respond to the mean voter position on to the supporters." *Party Politics* 17(3): 275-301.
- Giger, Natalie and Klüver, Heike. (2016), Voting Against Your Constituents? How Lobbying Affects Representation. *American Journal of Political Science*, 60: 190-205. doi:10.1111/ajps.12183
- Persson, Mikael, and Anders Sundell. 2023. "The Rich Have a Slight Edge: Evidence from Comparative Data on Income-Based Inequality in Policy Congruence." *British Journal of Political Science*: 1–12. doi: 10.1017/S0007123423000066.
- Walgrave, Stefaan et al. 2022. "Inaccurate Politicians: Elected Representatives' Estimations of Public Opinion in Four Countries." *The Journal of Politics*. 85(1): 209-222.

2.9. Lecture 9: The Swedish national election studies: over 60 years of electoral research

Henrik Ekengren Oscarsson

Abstract: This lecture introduces the SNES, one of the oldest and longest running election studies in the world. It provides a review of recent and historical findings on the Swedish Voter and an account of stability or change in Swedish electoral behavior. Which models of voting behavior have dominated in the past and what is the picture right now vis a vis the Swedish electorate? What accounts for the dominance of the Social Democrats in the better part of the 20th century and what does SNES research tell us about the rise of the Sweden Democrats? Are there notable fluctuations in various concepts such as party identification, indicators such as turnout or important attitudes such as political trust across time? How do developments on electoral behavior in Sweden compare to those in other Western democracies and the US? These are some indicative questions that will be covered during this lecture.

- Holmberg, Sören & Henrik Oscarsson (2016) Electoral Behavior. In Pierre (2016) (Ed) *The Handbook of Swedish Politics*. London: Oxford University press (e-book).
- Oscarsson, Henrik, & Rosema, Martin (2019). "Consideration set models of electoral choice: Theory, method, and application", *Electoral studies*, 57, 256-262
- Oscarsson, Henrik & Strömbäck, Jesper (2019). "Political communication in the 2018 Swedish election campaign. *Statsvetenskaplig Tidskrift*, vol. 121: 3, pp. 319-345.

2.10. Lecture 10. Election campaigns: professionalized, marketized; individualized?

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: This lecture focuses on the election campaigns from the point of view of the political parties. The history of election campaigns is outlined and discussed by relating to the concepts of 'professionalization' and 'marketization'. What do we mean by professionalized campaigns? And have parties come to use market-like approaches to their communications with the voters? There is also a discussion on campaigning on social media and how different platforms may yield different engagement and responses by voters.

- Boulianne, Shelley & Larsson, Anders Olof (2023) Engagement with candidate posts on Twitter, Instagram, and Facebook during the 2019 election. *New Media & Society* 25:1, 119-140.
- Lees-Marshment, Jennifer (2001). The marriage of politics and marketing. *Political Studies*. Vol 49: 692-713.
- Lilleker, Darren G. and Negrine Ralph (2002). Professionalization: Of What? Since When? By Whom? *The Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics*. 2002 (7): 98.
- Mykkänen, Juri, Nord, Lars & Moring, Tom (2021) Ten years after: Is the party-centered theory of campaign professionalization still valid? *Party Politics* 1-11.
- Iyengar *Media Politics*. Chapters 5+6 (optional)

2.11. Lecture 11. Election campaigns: negative campaigning

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: The lecture discusses so-called negative campaigning, which is a common feature in political campaigns, especially in the US. How widespread is the strategy to go negative, how can it be explained and what are the effects – on voters and democracy? The lecture gives a short overview of trends, characteristics and consequences of negative campaigning, and of course looks at some famous examples.

- Enns-Jedenastik, Laurenz, Dolezal, Martin, & Müller, Wolfgang C. (2017). Gender Differences in Negative Campaigning: The Impact of Party Environments. *Politics & Gender*, 13(1), 81-106.

- Lau, Richard R., Sigelman, Lee, & Rovner, Ivy Brown (2007). The effects of negative political campaigns: a metaanalytic reassessment. *Journal of Politics*, 69(4), 1176-1209.
- Valli, Chiara & Nai, Alessandro (2020) Attack politics from Albania to Zimbabwe: A large-scale comparative study on the drivers of negative campaigning. *International Political Science Review* 1-17.
- Walter, Annemarie. S. (2014). Negative campaigning in Western Europe: Similar or different?. *Political Studies*, 62(1_suppl), 42-60.
- Iyengar *Media Politics*. Chapter 5+6. (optional)

2.12. Lecture 12. Media effect theories

Isabella Glogger

Abstract: The question of how the news media influences citizens and in particular public opinion is probably as old as the news media itself. Research on media effects is, thus, considered one of the key areas of communication and political science. In this lecture, we first cast a glance back to the beginnings of media effect theories before addressing classic media effect theories, such as agenda-setting theory or framing. The lecture also examines contemporary perspectives, such as the Reinforcing Spiral Model.

- Djerf-Pierre, M. & Shehata, A. (2017). Still an Agenda Setter: Traditional New Media and Public Opinion During the Transition From Low to High-Choice Media Environments. *Journal of Communication*, 67(5), 733-757.
- Scheufele, D. A., & Tewksbury, D. (2007). Framing, agenda setting, and priming: The evolution of three media effects models. *Journal of Communication*, 57(1), 9-20.
- Slater, M. D., Shehata, A., & Strömbäck, J. (2020). Reinforcing Spirals Model. In J. Bulck (Ed.), *The International Encyclopedia of Media Psychology* (pp. 1–11). Wiley.
<https://doi.org/10.1002/9781119011071.iemp0134>

2.13. Lecture 13. Changing media environments: Threat to democracy?

Isabella Glogger

Abstract: A well-functioning society relies on citizens staying informed about current societal and political events. Recent changes in the news media and political information environment pose a threat to this necessity. In this lecture, we focus on concerns that are associated with obstacles for knowledge acquisition in such changing environments, such as citizens increasingly avoiding the news and encountering misinformation/disinformation. We discuss, furthermore, remedies for these problematic developments, for example, fact-checking initiatives or media literacy interventions.

- Broda, E., & Strömbäck, J. (2024). Misinformation, disinformation, and fake news: lessons from an interdisciplinary, systematic literature review. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, 48(2), 139–166. [only pp: 139-144]
<https://doi.org/10.1080/23808985.2024.2323736>

- Castro, L., Strömbäck, J., Esser, F. ... Theocharis, Y. (2022). Navigating High-Choice European Political Information Environments: A Comparative Analysis of News User Profiles and Political Knowledge. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 27(4), 827–859. <https://doi.org/10.1177/19401612211012572>
- Damstra, A., Vliegenthart, R., Boomgaarden, H., Glüer, K., Lindgren, E., Strömbäck, J., & Tsifti, Y. (2023). Knowledge and the News: An Investigation of the Relation Between News Use, News Avoidance, and the Presence of (Mis)beliefs. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 28(1), 29–48. <https://doi.org/10.1177/19401612211031457>
- Hameleers, M. (2022). Separating truth from lies: Comparing the effects of news media literacy interventions and fact-checkers in response to political misinformation in the US and Netherlands. *Information, communication & society*, 25(1), 110-126.
- Skovsgaard, M., & Andersen, K. (2020). Conceptualizing News Avoidance: Towards a Shared Understanding of Different Causes and Potential Solutions. *Journalism Studies*, 21(4), 459–476. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1461670X.2019.1686410>

2.14. Lecture 14. Mediatization – the impact of media on politics

Nicklas Håkansson

Abstract: The concept of mediatization is one of the most used in contemporary research on media impact on politics. But what is mediatization? What are the origins of the concept, definitions and critique? Is there research showing any proof of a growing mediatization of politics?

- Bastien, Frédérick. (2018). Using parallel content analysis to measure mediatization of politics: The televised leaders' debates in Canada, 1968–2008. *Journalism*:1-19.
- Hallin, Daniel C. (2021) Rethinking mediatization. Populism and the mediatization of politics. In Tumber, H., & Waisbord, S. (Eds.). *The Routledge Companion to Media Disinformation and Populism* (1st ed.). Routledge. <https://doi-org.ezproxy.ub.gu.se/10.4324/9781003004431>
- Hjarvard, Stig (2008). The Mediatization of Society. *Nordicom Review* 29(2):105-129.
- Ketelaars, Pauline & Van Aelst, Peter (2021) An actor approach to mediatization. *Politics of the Low Countries* 3:1.
- Strömbäck, Jesper (2008). Four Phases of Mediatization. An Analysis of the Mediatization of Politics. *International Journal of Press/Politics*, vol. 13(3), pp. 228-246.

2.15. Written exam

The written exam covers only the literature for the first part of the course. It is a closed-book, sit-down exam with typically four questions. Example can be found on CANVAS.

Please note that you need to **sign up for the exam** well in advance, no later than 10 days before it takes place. If you don't sign up **you will be denied to write the exam**. For more information:

Make sure to bring a **valid** identity paper to the exam. Ask Maria Lilleste if you are unsure whether your identity paper is valid. Note that your student card is not considered a valid identity paper.

If you are late, you will be denied writing the exam. Make sure you know when you have to be there (you need to be there in advance).

Note that the exam is an electronic exam and that you need a computer with correct programs. Make sure you have read all instructions and have done all trials online well in advance. And again, make sure you follow their guidelines on how long you need to be there in advance. If you cannot bring your own computer, you must book one well ahead. Here you find information about the electronic exam:

<https://studentportal.gu.se/english/e-services/written-examination/in-the-exam-hall/?languageId=100001&skipSSOCheck=true>

Please also not that it is not allowed to consume certain types of foods during the exam, such as for example nuts.

If you are eligible to obtain special assistance for sitting the exam, please let Maria Lilleste (see email address on first page) know at least 4 weeks before the exam.

Students are encouraged to arrange a pre-exam seminar that they themselves design. A room is booked for this purpose.

3. The output-heavy side: Research review

3.1. Purpose and organization

Your task in the research review is to 1) formulate a broad research problem; 2) develop more specific research questions following from the general research problem, as well as 3) answer these research questions analytically based on existing research. Also, the review is the most important basis for your grade and the presentations provide you with a range of perspectives from your fellow student colleagues in several areas.

Students start working on their review after the written exam. A lecture introducing the review writing takes place after the exam.

We anticipate that the average report will be 4,000 words. Reports that are longer than 5,000 words will not be accepted.

A good report should do the following:

- Identify, develop, and propose an important research problem and specify research questions that follow well from the problem.

- Give reasonable, knowledge-based, answers to the questions you specify. Discuss the most important theoretical arguments found in the research literature, as well as the most relevant empirical results. Base your answer both on the course literature as well as additional references from the field. If relevant, include empirical illustrations from your own analyses. An important part of your essay is to discuss the strengths and weaknesses of the research you have taken into account: Are the theoretical ideas and empirical methods reasonable and sound? Do you buy the conclusions? Why/Why not? What types of studies are missing in order for research to answer the question properly?
- Provide a compelling argument regarding the democratic relevance of this research. In order to do this, you need to confront different normative models of democracy, grounded in democratic theory. To what extent do current democratic processes meet the standards of various normative models of democracy? What does this research suggest about how democratic processes could be improved, given that we want to realize certain democratic ideals and values?

You are free to organize your review anyway you like. Try to find the structure that works best for “the story” you want to tell. It is an analytical task for you to identify a nucleus of important ideas and research results, which will make for a coherent and readable review.

We expect you to follow standard rules for referencing and that you show that you have taken into account both course literature and additional literature suggested to you during supervision. Please note that it is good if you succeed in connecting your topic to parts of the course literature in this way, but we are not impressed by superficial “name dropping” doing little to improve the discussion. Don’t forget to include a list of references at the end of your review, so that others can comfortably read and use it in the future. Also, give your review a substantive title (rather than calling it “review”). Have a look at the rules for academic writing, including the use of AI tools. It summarizes what we expect from you.

3.2. The process of writing the review

Students are assisted during this phased of the course through a supervisor as well as peer-to-peer-element. It is mandatory to provide early, work-in-progress, versions of the review at the following four occasions (please find the dates/deadlines in the timetable):

1. Writing workshop 1: *Oral presentation and feedback of ideas among peers*. Students present their idea and get/give oral feedback from/to other students in their group. A lecturer will be around at least some of the time to answer small questions. The group jointly fill in and upload a protocol on CANVAS by the end of the session. Instructions and template for protocol is provided on CANVAS.
2. Supervision 1: You upload a *one-page introduction* where you formulate a specification of the research problem that will be investigated, as well as suggest specific research questions. You should also include a preliminary reference list outlining literature you intend to use. The course coordinator will match you with a supervisor, who comments your text briefly, as well as suggests more literature for you to consider. Teacher response will be given in writing within a day.
3. Supervision 2: You submit a *five-page* text in which you have re-written the specification of the research problem as well as the specific research questions – and where you provide a first draft of answers to the questions based on the literature you are studying. You will then sign up for a meeting with your supervisor where you will get further help with research problem/questions, as well as literature, but this time there will likely be a

stronger focus on the analytical parts of the text, where you attempt to answer the questions. You will get this feedback both in writing as well as in a personal meeting with the supervisor.

4. Writing workshop 2: Students bring two printed copies of their paper to other group members. All read two papers (divide as you see fit) and help by making notes in the text. Afterwards students discuss each paper for about 15 minutes, where the readers of the paper kick off the discussion. Focus is on constructive ways forward in theoretical and empirical arguments, not on format. A lecturer will be around at least some of the time to answer small questions. The groups fill in a joint protocol again. Instructions and template for protocol is provided on CANVAS.

After the second writing workshop, you have time to finalize your paper. It must be uploaded onto CANVAS at the specified deadline (see timetable).

3.3. The final seminar

During the final seminar, we have approximately 10 minutes for each presentation. Prepare your presentations thoroughly. No “reading out loud from the paper”. Power-point is the tool to use. Practice in front of your mom, friend, mirror, or neighbor. Don’t think that you can do a good presentation without such practice.

You are expected to contribute to the discussion in connection to the other presentations. A lecturer will be there to moderate the discussion. After the seminar, you will also get written feedback.

Here are the dimensions along which we evaluate your written and oral efforts:

	<u>Weak</u>	<u>Satisfactory</u>	<u>Excellent</u>
<u>1. COHERENCE:</u> Is there a clear story and argument throughout the review?			
<u>2. USE OF LITERATURE:</u> Does the review engage with relevant theories and empirical research found in the literature?			
<u>3. ORIGINALITY AND INDEPENDENCE:</u> Does the review develop perspectives and arguments that are based on but also go beyond the research literature?			
<u>4. DEMOCRATIC RELEVANCE:</u> How persuasively does the review engage with issues concerning the democratic implications of empirical research?			

4. Course requirements and grading

The following requirements apply for passing the course:

- Passing the online modules on academic integrity (1 and 2)

- Passing the written exam.
- A satisfactory review.
- A satisfactory oral presentation at the final day.
- Sending in two preliminary reviews to teachers and participating in one personal supervision.
- Participating in two writing workshops. In the first one you bring your idea and present it orally, in the second one you bring two paper copies for others to read and you comment yourself on two papers.
- Active participation in final seminar discussions.

The written exam, the review, the oral presentation, and seminar performance all affect the final grade. The two most important elements are the review and the exam. The exam is graded as pass (G), pass with distinction (VG) or not pass (U). The final version of the research review will only be graded (as U, G or VG). Participation in the workshops, supervision, and the final seminar is graded as U or G. Failure to participate in the above four steps will mean that additional tasks will be assigned for each missed step.

In order to pass the course (grade G), the student needs at least G on the written exam and the essay as well as show active participation in the supervision and discussion seminar. To pass the course with distinction (grade VG) the student needs VG on both the written exam and the essay as well as active participation in the supervision and discussion seminar.

5. Compensatory tasks

Each compensatory task will consist of writing a one-page home essay. The specific tasks are found below. They should be handed in at the specified deadline (see schedule), and will then be evaluated together with the other exams/reports within the three weeks-limit that the teachers have to finalize grades.

5.1. Compensatory tasks for missed supervision or workshop

Additional task for students missing one or both of the writing workshops or one or both of the supervision occasions during the writing of the research essay.

Your task is to **write a one-page (max. 500 words) home exam on one of the following subjects.** If you missed more than one of the four occasions you write 2, 3 respectively 4 exam questions and hand in a page-long answer of each.

The tasks will be graded by the next grading occasion after the end of the course. Grades are G/U and the texts will be commented by the teacher only if grading is borderline.

1. The Civic Voluntarism Model is an important explanation for political participation. Choose two peer-reviewed articles that are not on your reading list for the class and that use the model empirically and summarize how they operationalize the most important concepts of the model.
2. Political representation of young people is not easily achieved. Choose two peer-reviewed research articles that are not on your reading list for the class studying

youth representation and describe their main take-aways.

3. Election campaigning is assumed to have become professionalized over the years. Choose two articles that are not on your reading list for the class dealing with campaign professionalization and describe what they mean by professionalization.
4. Mediatization is often regarded as a general tendency of societal change. Often the concept is dealt with in theory. Here you should briefly outline two examples of empirical evidence of mediatization discussed in the literature. Choose articles that are not on the reading list of this course.

5.2. Compensatory tasks for missed final seminar (presentation and discussant)

Please see Canvas / Assignments for details!

6. About equal treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Lena Wängnerud, equal treatment representative Lisbeth Aggestam, or student counselor Sara Birgersson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these people if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if this is not directly aimed at you. All necessary contact information is available on our website.